Everyday HCI of Adaptive Fitness: The Bricolage of Self-Tracking in Urban India

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Abstract

Digital fitness technologies promise greater awareness, structured routines, and enhanced discipline, influencing how individuals construct notions of well-being and engage in fitness within social environments. In urban India, these dynamics are shaped by infrastructural constraints, uneven access to fitness resources, and context-specific conditions that complicate standardized tracking models built by global platforms. Drawing on prior literature studies and qualitative fieldwork, we examine how young fitness practitioners adopt and negotiate the use of self-tracking technologies. Using bricolage as an analytical lens, we suggest how users creatively repurpose tools, navigating data-driven guidance and embodied intuition. Our findings show three key themes: creation of hybrid self-tracking ecologies, technology domestication via selective appropriation, and adaptation of fitness tracking to local socio-material contexts. Fitness emerges as a situated and relational practice shaped by resource constraints and interpretive self-tracking.

CCS Concepts

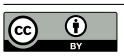
• **Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI**;

Keywords

Self-tracking, Urban India, Fitness practices, Qualitative study, Bricolage

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1 Introduction

Fitness technologies do more than measure activity; they shape how users sense their bodies, organise routines, and interpret progress, health, and well-being, highlighting the need for context-specific understandings of everyday fitness. Despite their global reach, dominant research and design paradigms largely emerge from Global North contexts, emphasising individualised goals [9, 31], numerical precision [8, 37], and performance optimisation [12, 15]. These approaches assume stable users, universal meanings of fitness, and access to advanced technologies. However, the 2018 India Report Card [20] shows that nearly half of Indian children and youth do not meet activity guidelines due to limited and restrictive infrastructure environments. Fitness practices in India do not simply replicate well-resourced models; they generate hybrid practices, blending digital systems with local understandings of health and embodiment while navigating limited access to affordable technologies. This paper reviews work across HCI, digital health, and sports science and integrates qualitative research - interviews, observations, and affinity mapping - from fitness spaces in urban India, examining not only what technologies are used for but how they become part of everyday and embodied practice. Using the concept of 'bricolage' as a framework [23], we show how young people assemble workable fitness systems from limited resources rather than using technologies as designed. Bricolage involves working with what is at hand - balancing goals and constraints, and combining apps, wearables, trainer feedback, bodily sensations, and social cues to make fitness affordable and sustainable. When facing technological limits, users adapt rather than abandon tools, using free alternatives or analogue aids. These hybrid ecologies combine digital tools with handwritten journals, mirrors, and embodied memory. Users display everyday design literacy by repurposing devices, customising dashboards, and layering scripts or spreadsheets, becoming co-designers of their systems. Because fitness is socially and culturally situated, participants draw on Indian influencers, WhatsApp groups, local gyms, and family feedback, placing practice at the intersection of local contexts and global digital flows. By foregrounding these adaptive practices, the paper challenges assumptions of uniform, metric-driven fitness use and argues for designs that embrace hybridity, flexibility, and users' negotiation of quantified data. Our paper makes the following contributions to

HCI and fitness technology research: an empirical account of fitness technology use in urban India beyond contexts from the Global North; the concept of hybrid fitness tracking ecologies showing how users combine digital and analogue practices over time; and an account of everyday design literacy, demonstrating how users customise, repurpose, and co-design their systems.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Quantified Self-tracking

Contemporary fitness technologies emerge mostly from Western sports science and HCI, where the main focus is on tracking and improving how the body performs with reference to standardised performance ideals. Sports science, rooted in physiological ideas about load, recovery, and metabolic efficiency, breaks the body into functional components, translating everyday bodily processes into measurable metrics - steps, calories, sleep scores, and heart rate variability - presenting them through dashboards and algorithmic summaries. [12, 31]. Numbers are seen as objective health markers that shape goals and habits, encouraging people to trust technology over their own bodily sensations [9, 22]. Fitness and wellness technologies in HCI are often designed as structured systems to change behaviour, guiding users' habits through nudges, feedback, and gamified interactions [9, 29]. This design logic aligns with the 'Quantified Self' movement, conceptualising self-tracking as a means of producing insight through data accumulation [8, 39]. These systems often presume a certain kind of user: resources to use technology, data literacy, and stable routines enabling engagement over time [28, 31]. While such systems can promote accountability and adherence, they risk narrowing fitness into a continuous performance check - something to optimise for, rather than feel. In practice, self-tracking carries emotional weight: meeting targets can produce pride and a sense of control, while missed days or "bad" scores often trigger guilt, frustration, or disengagement [1, 40]. In response, recent work has called for moving beyond the 'Quantified Self' towards the 'Qualified Self' where metrics are interpreted through reflection, narrative, and situated context rather than treated as definitive truths [36, 37]. While HCI research emphasizes reflective and interpretive engagements with personal data [2], commercial fitness technologies continue to favor numerical metrics that reduce embodied experiences into dashboards, targets, and streaks [24] . This reinforces a paradigm of measurement, optimization, and numerical accountability [14, 21, 33], privileging quantification over situated understanding [2, 40]. We revisit this critique in Section 5.

2.2 Fitness Technology Use in Urban Indian Contexts

Studies examining fitness technology in India have largely relied on surveys and gym logs over qualitative investigations. One study using standardised scales for exercise behaviour and body esteem found clearer differences in body esteem across exercise categories for men than for women, suggesting that body image mediates excessive exercise and perceived pressure. However, it offered limited insight into how body image is actually lived and experienced [10]. Another study examined adherence to fitness routines, linking fitness to attendance through social participation, while attributing dropout to lack of time, limited equipment knowledge, and poor access to trainers [34]. Survey work on self-tracking in India frames it within a broader culture of measurement, showing both perceived benefits (motivation and insights) and risks (increased pressure and self-judgement), highlighting that users were less concerned about data privacy and more focused on what their quantified data revealed to them [1]. Studies on Indian youth further argue that social media use and "fitspiration" can reinforce self-objectification and poorer mental well-being via the metric-driven logic of progress, discipline, and optimization in fitness practices [6, 11]. Other studies point to uneven conditions shaping practice: activity-supportive institutional curricula show higher activity than the Indian adult average [38], mapping studies document poor-quality fitness resources in mid-sized Indian cities [16], and observational survey work reports male gym-goers pursuing muscle-building, weight loss, and cardio while lacking expert training knowledge [32]. Together, these studies establish pressures and constraints, but remain partial, relying largely on quantitative and survey evidence. This demands a qualitative study of how urban Indian practitioners adopt, interpret, and repurpose fitness technologies in context.

2.3 Bricolage as an Analytical Lens

We use bricolage as an analytical lens to examine how fitness practitioners create workable solutions despite technology and infrastructure constraints. Originating in Lévi-Strauss's account of the bricoleur [19, 23], bricolage refers to 'making do' with what is at hand, assembling workable solutions from limited tools rather than using tools for fixed, intended purposes [23]. It describes a mode of action based on pragmatic recomposition shaped by local context and constraint, not optimisation towards an ideal design [13, 19]. The concept has since moved into sociology and organisational design studies to explain practices through improvisation, repair, and recombination under uncertainty and scarcity [3, 26]. In technology research, bricolage highlights the gap between system intent and lived practice where activities stabilise over time in real conditions [36]. We use bricolage to interpret fitness as a practice shaped by what is available, feasible, and meaningful.

3 Methodology

This study adopts a qualitative research design to examine how fitness technologies shape everyday practices and perceptions of well-being, embodiment, and progress among urban Indian fitness practitioners. Rather than evaluating technologies in isolation, we treat fitness technology use as a situated, culturally embedded, and relational practice shaped by social interaction, bodily routine, and sense-making. Our approach is informed by prior self-tracking work that overemphasises Western, quantitative contexts, often overlooking user integration into lived experiences. We therefore focus on how users interpret data, understand their bodies, and how they negotiate ideas of health, effort, and well-being. We used a multi-method strategy combining in-depth interviews and in-situ observation. Participants were recruited through gyms, running groups, and snowball sampling across fitness spaces in Hyderabad, a metropolis in South India and Gwalior, a city in central India, because the authors had access to participants in these cities. The final sample included 24 participants [P1 to P24] aged 18–28, comprising

students and early-career working professionals, including gym-goers, bodybuilders, runners, and those new to structured fitness; 12 % of the sample were women. We conducted 24 semi-structured interviews (60 – 90 minutes) covering fitness histories, technology adoption, daily practices, and how technology shaped bodily awareness and well-being. Interviews were in the English language and audio-recorded and transcribed manually; the transcripts and field notes formed the primary corpus of our analysis. Most used combinations of digital and non-digital tools - trackers, apps, machines, handwritten logs, trainers, and social media - which enabled us to examine hybrid fitness practices. Observations across diverse gyms captured variation in class, equipment, and gym culture, including interactions with gym equipment, data interpretation, peer dynamics, and self-surveillance. Field notes documented patterns of equipment use and the social and affective atmosphere surrounding fitness practices, particularly within the gymnasiums frequented by our participants. Transcripts and notes were segmented into data points and coded inductively [7, 17], after which affinity mapping [4, 5], was used to develop clusters and themes. Using Canva, data were arranged as digital sticky notes for spatial clustering. Iterative grouping identified patterns in metric-driven self-evaluation, bodily intuition, social comparison, discipline, and cycles of motivation and disengagement. Clusters were organised hierarchically [27] to map temporal trajectories from novelty-driven motivation to sustained practice. Bricolage thus became an interpretive lens for theme refinement, rather than a pre-defined coding framework. The first three authors conducted fieldwork through interviews and participant observations. Interview analysis and the development of findings were undertaken collaboratively by all four authors. Participants were informed of the study's purpose and their role before data collection. Informed consent was obtained, and participants could withdraw at any time. To ensure confidentiality, all identifying details were removed, and potentially revealing information was omitted. [The Appendix contains the participant table, interview guide, and details of the affinity mapping]

4 Findings

We frame fitness tracking as a dynamic negotiation of control, agency, and relevance. Themes in this section illustrate how participants, over time, became less dependent on digital metrics and prioritized an intuitive, body-led approach.

4.1 Bricolage of Hybrid Self-Tracking Ecologies and Everyday Innovation

Fitness adaptations transformed standardised technologies into meaningful systems aligned with local and accessible fitness infrastructure. Participants built hybrid ecologies of fitness tracking, combining digital tools (apps, wearables) with analogue methods (journals, mirrors, memory, bodily sensation). These ecosystems were not ad hoc but deliberately configured based on task utility. For example, participants contextualised calorie counts through home-cooked meals, reshaped goal-setting around festivals or family routines, and modified workout splits using local norms of balance and proportion. The latter was modified from specific forms of self-knowledge rather than incidental use. P12 noted: "Before I could afford a Garmin, I made an Excel file with tabs for each muscle group. I still use it because it gives me the analysis I want something no app has." Others stressed limits to 'metrics' and the value of reflection. P3 said, "I keep a journal about how workouts affect my mood and energy - things apps don't capture." Digital tools were supplemented, not abandoned. P1 explained, "If the app misses an exercise, I write it in my phone notes. I still prefer a physical notebook for new programs - it feels more intentional." Together, these accounts show fitness tracking shaped by negotiations between metrics, culture, and embodied knowledge, producing systems beyond platform designers' intent. Participants showed strong everyday design literacy, reconfiguring devices and software to fit practice. Rather than using single apps, they built personalised infrastructures by repurposing tools, writing scripts, and adapting materials, acting as co-designers who valued flexibility and meaning over polish. P2 said, "I wrote a Python script to pull Google Fit data and make weekly summaries I like." Others chose generic tools for customisation. P1 noted, "I use Google Sheets for progressive overload. It's not a fitness app, but I can tailor it." Participants also rejected rigid systems. P12 said, "I log not just what I did, but also my sleep patterns and stress levels — apps focus on the what, not the why." P2 added, "I'd rather make do with something at hand than pay for something...flashy." When probed, P2 admitted 'flashy' also meant 'unaffordable'. Overall, fitness tracking emerges as an ongoing end-user design, where systems are continually adjusted to local needs and meanings, reflecting users' active negotiation of control, agency, and relevance.

4.2 Bricolaging Embodied and Affective Feedback Over Metrics

While gamified features like badges, streaks, and targets supported short-term engagement, sustained motivation came from embodied, affective, and social feedback. Participants valued bodily sensations (energy, pain, ease), visual cues (appearance, fit of clothes), and social affirmation over abstract numbers. They stressed the limits of metrics and the importance of sensory inputs. P3 said, "I keep a simple journal about how exercise affects my mood and energy - things apps don't capture." P4 added, "I tune into how my body feels. No tracker can tell you if your shoulder is compromised." Many set aside numbers for body-led engagement. P2 said, "I just tuned into how my body felt - no numbers, no targets, just me and the workout." Visual self-assessment was often more motivating than data. P8 said, "Seeing yourself in the mirror after a workout, that's what motivates me." P2 added, "Sometimes visual progress is more motivating than any number." These practices were usually private: "I use mirrors and photos not social media, just for myself." Overall, users treated metrics as temporary scaffolds, privileging embodied judgment, feeling, and situated meanings of progress.

4.3 Localized and Culturally Embedded Fitness Practices supporting Bricolage

Fitness practices were shaped by local routines, social expectations, and infrastructural limits. While platforms assume global lifestyles - fixed meal times, standard diets, predictable schedules - participants adapted them to Indian food, work, climate, and family life. They noted gaps between app assumptions and reality. P12 said, "Most apps are Western-based. They assume you eat at 6 p.m. or have

certain equipment… They don't understand that dal–chawal is a full meal." Participants developed personal workarounds. P3 said, "I keep rough calorie templates in my head. Apps that need special ingredients are useless to me." Work routines mattered too. P2 said, "Apps don't get our work culture - late-night U.S. calls, erratic schedules, hot summers." Family and local cultures also shaped practice. P14 said, "Fitness runs in my family - my dad runs marathons, my mom is active… I grew up cycling with my dad." Participants mixed global trends with local figures to build fitness practices that fit their own social, cultural, and material worlds.

4.4 Bricolage of Adaptive Engagement and Goal Setting

Fitness technology use was contextual and fluid, shifting with work pressure, injury, motivation, fatigue, and life stage. Rather than steady engagement, participants moved through cycles of intense use - during training or renewed motivation - and periods of low use during illness, recovery, or heavy work or study. Rhythms varied: P10 said, "I check my data once every two or three weeks," P4 said, "I usually review things on Sunday evenings." Some checked steps daily, but deeper data only occasionally. Work and study often disrupted routines: P14 said, "When deadlines come up, I skip the gym... also Apps can't know if I had a long day or slept badly." Users adjusted goals dynamically: P19 explained, "Sometimes I go twice a week, sometimes five or six… right now about four days—callisthenics, weights, running." These patterns show fitness tracking as episodic and adaptive, not a steady path of optimisation.

5 Design Tensions and Opportunities

5.1 Supporting Interoperable Bricolage and Hybrid Tracking Ecologies through User-Extensible Systems

There is a tension between closed-platform workflows and everyday hybrid practice. Self-tracking is rarely limited to a single tool or fixed workflow. Yet, many fitness platforms still operate with a limited understanding of what users actually do, presuming fixed, closed workflows. Our findings show that users instead build hybrid ecologies by layering digital and analog tools with personal records and everyday fitness practices to make tracking workable in context. Designing for bricolage in low-resource contexts, therefore, demands interoperability across heterogeneous practices and user-extensible systems that let people repurpose tools and recombine resources for situated needs. Design should support seamless data import and export, portability across platforms, and template-based customization for locally meaningful categories. Systems should also allow features to be adopted, ignored, or replaced without penalty. Because continuity is an inherent feature of hybrid ecologies, platforms should not assume an ideal journey; instead, support it, especially during periods when users rely more on non-digital practices.

5.2 Subjective and Temporal Adaptation in Phase-Based Engagement

There is a strong underlying tension between continuous metric accumulation and episodic, embodied engagement. Fitness tracking is not a steady accumulation, but an adaptive practice shaped by work pressure, injury, fatigue, and life stage. This aligns with critiques of data-centric self-tracking, where metrics can obscure lived experience and narrow what counts as progress [25, 30]. Prior studies describe cycles of experimentation, routine, breakdown, and disengagement as inherent to tracking [14, 35]. Our findings suggest that long-term engagement isn't dependent on metrics alone, but on users' ability to recognise and act on subjective signals such as tiredness, recovery, or energy levels. Designers should therefore acknowledge that engagement fluctuates, and breaks need to be treated as "normal" rather than a sign of failure. Feedback should ground reflection by pairing numerical metrics with subjective markers. A concrete direction is phase-based tracking templates that allow users to shift between intensive tracking, maintenance, and recovery without losing continuity.

5.3 Socially Situated Design and Fitting Fitness Goals

There is a tension between platform-standardized assumptions and locally situated fitness practice. Many platforms encode assumptions about food, meal timing, climate, routines, and social life that do not generalize well [18]. Our findings reveal that progress is often negotiated at the confluence of personal goals and social or practical realities, rather than derived solely from platform targets. When data conflicts with embodied experience, it can erode trust. Users then adapt goals to remain meaningful and socially sustainable. Systems should therefore support this goal negotiation, rather than rigid, often stressful enforcement. Design should enable flexible goals and custom categories that accommodate local routines, seasons, and dynamic social demands. Alongside this, systems should support accountability as a negotiated social practice, rather than constant self-surveillance and monitoring. While participants value the support from friends and family, they often resist the visibility that comes with it: support can blur into unwanted comparison. Platforms should therefore default to bounded audiences and user-mediated data sharing, enabling people to choose who can see what, when, and for what purpose. Designing accountability around consent and context - rather than rank and exposure - keeps fitness a situated practice embedded in everyday well-being, not a constant optimisation regime

6 Conclusion

This study establishes a critical baseline for understanding fitness tracking within urban Indian infrastructure. The findings are bound by the scope of our qualitative dataset and the contextual settings examined. Accordingly, we construct an interpretive account of how people make fitness tracking workable and meaningful under constraint, rather than a standardized model of fitness practices. We propose to extend this study for a full paper by incorporating an extended literature review and expanding our findings by mining more diverse qualitative data.

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